

Asia Chart Alert

Global Markets Research

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Economics - Asia ex-Japan

Nomura's leading index of Asian exports

NELI continues to signal a robust yet bifurcated upswing in Asia's export growth.

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Fig. 1: Nomura's leading index of Asian exports



- Nomura's leading index of Asia ex-Japan's aggregate exports, or NELI for short, comprises nine components and has a three-month lead time. NELI has correctly predicted past major turning points and is less distorted by base effects than official export data, making it a good momentum leading indicator of Asia's underlying export growth.
- NELI climbed for the fourth month in a row to 117.7 in June, the highest reading since July 2010. This signals that Asia's export growth should continue its robust uptrend. However, there is significant bifurcation within the region.
- NELI's rise in June is primarily driven by a strong upswing in tech-related indicators, led by the Philadelphia Semiconductor Index, which expanded at a triple-digit pace on a y-o-y basis, alongside an improvement in China's imports from the rest of Asia. AI tech-driven economies, such as Taiwan and Korea, are leading the export upswing. Export growth in the non-tech sectors and some ASEAN countries is more subdued.
- Geopolitical risks remain a swing factor. A prolonged Middle East conflict could disrupt supply chains, raise shipping costs and weaken external demand, constraining Asia's export upswing. In the near term, we will watch Korea's first 20-day May export data, due on 21 May, for a timely read on Asia's trade pulse.

Note: Nomura's export leading index can be found on Bloomberg (see ticker: NMEIXLI). Asia ex-Japan's aggregate (nominal) exports include those of China, Hong Kong, India, Indonesia, South Korea, Malaysia, the Philippines, Singapore, Taiwan and Thailand. China's exports to Hong Kong are excluded due to outsized swings on some occasions that seem unrelated to trade activity. Nomura's export leading index is a weighted (inverse of mean-squared errors) sum of the following Z-score standardized variables: Shanghai Shipping Exchange Containerized Freight Index, China's imports, China's imports from Asia, global semiconductor sales, US manufacturing ISM, S&P EM manufacturing PMI, China RatingDog (formerly Caixin) manufacturing PMI, South Korea's semiconductor exports and Philadelphia Semiconductor index. (For more details on its construction, see [Re-calibrating our Asia export leading index](#), 16 August 2022).

Source: IHS Markit, CEIC, Bloomberg and Nomura Global Economics.

Appendix A-1

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